

1. Modoc Resistance to Removal

The Modoc people resisted removal in several ways. After being forced into the reservation following the 1864 treaty, where they were harassed by the Indians and went hungry, the leader, Kentapus, asked the agent-in-charge, O.C. Knapp, for help. When he was ignored on the third try, he declared that "I may be an Indian, but I am not a dog," and he left and went back to the homelands of the Lost River. The Modocs adapted rather than retreated – some worked as ranch hands, while others charged settlers rent for their land. After the fight, roughly 55 warriors and their families ran to the lava beds, using natural trenches, caves, and rock walls as defense. The most significant act of resistance was when the men, women, and children together snuck out of the stronghold, with the help of other warriors who lit fires and fired shots to create the illusion of a larger force.

2. How Government Involvement Contributed to the War

Government involvement directly drove the conflict. The 1864 treaty forced distinct tribes into one single cramped reservation in Klamath, where the Modocs were abused. When settlers complained about the Modocs returning to the Lost River, the government approved to remove them "peaceably if you possibly can, but forcibly if you must," and with the use of cavalry from Klamath. This raid started the Lost River Battle when soldiers attempted to disarm the Modocs, and the two leaders exchanged fire. After this, the Modocs were ordered to be exterminated. Therefore, the "peace treaty" turned into a full assault on Indian culture while demanding that all native people go into reservations.

3. How Government Inaction and Absence Contributed to the War

In 1852, the California legislature went on to hunt Indians, and there were no consequences when they lured a Modoc village in under a white truce flag and killed 30 of their men, women, and children. The unpunished massacre made the Modoc feel that the rules of war had already been broken. After the 1864 treaty, the federal government didn't ratify it for years, assuming the Modocs would give up their land. This led to the Modoc people going hungry due to the annuities arriving late, and they went as far as killing their horses for food. According to the video, even the move on the Lost River was not government-authorized, meaning the Modocs had no idea that the whites were negotiating a way.